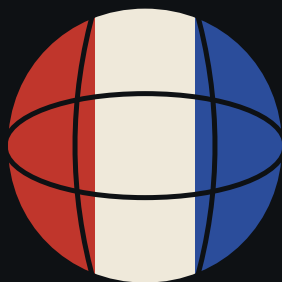


IF THE TRUTH BE TOLD

*Why the ABA Out-Played, Out-Coached, and Out-Souled the NBA —
and How History Got Rewritten by the League That Bought It*



RALPH SIMPSON

FIVE-TIME ABA ALL-STAR

If the Truth Be Told

Why the ABA Out-Played, Out-Coached, and Out-Souled the NBA

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INTRODUCTION

Before You Believe Another Highlight Reel



Let me tell you who this book is for, and why I waited fifty years to write it.

You’ve been told a story about basketball. It goes like this: the NBA was always the big league, the real league, the best league — and somewhere off to the side there was a circus called the American Basketball Association, a novelty act with a beach ball and no defense, which the NBA graciously absorbed in 1976 the way a museum takes in a curiosity.

That story is a lie. Not a mistake — a lie. And I know it’s a lie because I lived on the other side of it. My name is Ralph Simpson. I played in the ABA from 1970 until the day the league’s lights went out, made five All-Star teams in a Denver uniform, and shared floors, locker rooms, and long airport nights with Julius Erving, George Gervin, David Thompson, Dan Issel, and men whose names you’ve never heard who could flat-out play. Then I crossed over into the NBA after the merger and saw, up close, exactly what the “superior” league was made of.

If the truth be told — and in these pages it finally will be — the best of the ABA was better than the best of the NBA. Our top players were better. Our coaches were sharper and braver. Our game was faster, freer, more inventive, and more honest about what basketball was becoming.

Our red, white, and blue ball wasn't a gimmick; it was a flag. And the culture we carried — the afros, the soul, the swagger, the joy — is the culture the NBA has been selling to the world ever since, without ever sending the ABA a royalty check. If you've seen the documentary work being done on this era — the kind of testimony captured in films like *Soul Power*, streaming on Prime Video — you already know the witnesses are still alive and still telling it. This book is my testimony.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

This book is for three kinds of readers:

- **The young fan** who thinks basketball history began with Magic and Bird, and deserves to know where the three-pointer, the dunk contest, and the whole modern game actually came from.
- **The old head** who remembers the ABA in fragments — a colorful ball, a Doctor operating in the dark — and wants the full case, laid out with receipts.
- **The truth-seeker** who suspects, correctly, that history is written by whoever owns the television contract.

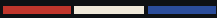
WHAT YOU'LL WALK AWAY WITH

By the last page, you will be able to argue this case yourself — in the barbershop, in the group chat, at the family cookout — and win. You'll know the players, the coaches, the head-to-head results the NBA never advertised, the merger terms that read like a ransom note, and the avalanche of ABA men who walked into the NBA in 1976 and took it over immediately. More than that, you'll never watch a modern NBA game the same way again, because you'll finally see it for what it is: the ABA's game, wearing the NBA's logo.

They bought our league. They could never buy the truth. Turn the page.

CHAPTER ONE

The League They Couldn't Kill — So They Bought It



Nine years. Two leagues. Only one of them was afraid.

On February 2, 1967, a group of businessmen announced a new professional basketball league and hired the most famous big man in the history of the sport to run it: George Mikan, the NBA's own first superstar. Read that again. The founding commissioner of the “outlaw” league was the man the NBA had built its early legend on. From day one, the ABA wasn't hiding from basketball royalty. It was recruiting it.

The American Basketball Association tipped off that fall with teams in cities the NBA had ignored or abandoned — Indianapolis, Louisville, Denver, New Orleans, Dallas — and a simple, dangerous idea: basketball could be *more*. More athletic. More open. More fun to watch. More generous to the men who actually played it. Mikan gave the league its signature red, white, and blue ball and its signature weapon, the three-point shot, and the race was on.

UNDERSTAND WHAT “SURVIVAL” MEANT

People love to bring up the ABA's empty arenas and folding franchises, as if instability proves inferiority. Flip it around. The NBA had a twenty-year head start, the big media markets, the television deal, and

the newspapers. The ABA had none of that — no national TV contract to speak of, no friendly press, no cushion. And yet the league survived **nine full seasons**, signed away NBA stars and NBA referees, beat NBA teams on the floor when they finally dared to play us, and cornered the market on the best young talent in America. A circus doesn't do that. A threat does that.

Ask yourself the only question that matters: if the ABA was a joke, why did the NBA spend nine years and millions of dollars in bidding wars trying to make it go away — and when that failed, why did the NBA *pay* to end the fight? You don't negotiate a merger with a punchline. You negotiate with an opponent who is beating you where it hurts.

THE WAR NOBODY CALLED A WAR

From 1967 to 1976, the two leagues fought on every front:

- **The talent front.** Rick Barry, the NBA's scoring champion, jumped to the ABA. Zelmo Beaty jumped. Billy Cunningham jumped. Meanwhile the ABA signed the best collegians — Erving, Gilmore, McGinnis, Thompson — before the NBA could even draft some of them.
- **The money front.** Salaries across professional basketball tripled and quadrupled because, for the first time, players had two bidders. Every pension and every contract a player signed in the 1970s owed something to the ABA's existence.
- **The style front.** The ABA played tomorrow's basketball — spacing, pace, the deep ball, the dunk — while too much of the NBA was still walking the ball up the floor and grinding out 98 possessions of elbows.

By 1976 the NBA had seen enough. It took our four strongest franchises — Denver, New York, San Antonio, Indiana — charged them each millions for the privilege of surrender, and told the world it had “absorbed” a failing league. Then ABA players immediately filled its All-Star Games and Finals rosters, and ABA innovations became the NBA’s entire product. That’s not absorption. That’s a hostile takeover where the hostages ended up running the building.

THE FRAME FOR THIS WHOLE BOOK

Every chapter that follows tests one claim from three angles: the **players** (Chapters 4–6), the **coaches** (Chapter 7), and the **game itself** (Chapters 8–11). Then the merger and its aftermath (Chapters 12–13) provide the controlled experiment: what happened when the two leagues finally shared one floor? Spoiler — my league won the peace.

But before we get to evidence, you need to understand the thing the ABA had that couldn’t be measured. It bounced. It was red, white, and blue. And it meant something.

CHAPTER TWO

A Ball in Three Colors: Style as a Declaration of War



The NBA had a ball. We had a statement.

George Mikan said he wanted a ball you could see from the cheap seats and a ball that looked beautiful spinning on a fingertip or arcing through the lights on a twenty-five-foot rainbow. The brown ball disappears in the air. Ours announced itself. Every possession in the ABA arrived in red, white, and blue, like the game itself was waving a banner: *something different is happening here.*

NBA people laughed at that ball for nine years. Then watch what happened after 1976: the dunk contest they adopted, the three-point line they adopted, the All-Star weekend carnival they adopted — and to this day, when a playground anywhere in America wants to signal “real hoop, real flavor,” somebody brings out a red, white, and blue ball. The most mocked piece of equipment in sports history became one of the most beloved. That tells you everything about how ABA ideas age.

STYLE WAS SUBSTANCE

Here is what the critics never understood: the ABA’s style was its basketball argument. A league built on the fast break, the lob, the deep jumper, and the dunk is making a claim about what wins — that speed

beats size, that space beats muscle, that skill and creativity are not decorations on the game but the game itself. Fifty years later, every NBA analytics department agrees with us. Pace and space, the corner three, the athletic wing who can handle and fly — that's not modern basketball. That's ABA basketball with a better camera crew.

And the showmanship wasn't desperation, whatever the historians say. Yes, we had halftime cow-milking contests in Indiana and giveaway nights that got out of hand. We were fighting for every ticket with no television to carry the story. But between the whistles, the show was the substance: Julius cradling the ball in one hand like a grapefruit, David Thompson taking off from angles that didn't seem legal, George Gervin finger-rolling from the free-throw line. The NBA sold basketball as an appointment. We sold it as an *experience* — and the experience is what the world eventually bought.

WHAT THE THREE COLORS STOOD FOR

- **Freedom.** Freedom for a college sophomore to feed his family (Chapter 3). Freedom for a player to fly instead of standing in a low post waiting for permission.
- **Identity.** The ABA let a man be himself — his hair, his handle, his celebration, his voice. In 1970 that was radical. Today it's the entire marketing plan of professional basketball.
- **Defiance.** Every time that tricolor ball went up, it said the old league's way was not the only way. The old league heard it loud and clear — that's why they hated the ball most of all.

TRY THIS TONIGHT

Watch ten minutes of any 1970s NBA game you can find, then ten minutes of ABA footage — the 1976 Finals between the Nets and Nuggets is on video and worth every second. Ignore the film quality. Just count the possessions that end in a play you'd put on a highlight reel today. Then ask yourself which league modern basketball actually descends from. You won't need me for the answer.

Style opened the door. But the ABA's deepest revolution wasn't aesthetic — it was moral. It started with a kid from Detroit named Spencer Haywood, and it changed the economics of the sport forever. I know, because I walked through that same door twelve months behind him.

CHAPTER THREE

The Hardship Door: How the ABA Set the Player Free



Before player empowerment was a hashtag, it was an ABA contract.

In 1969, the NBA had a gentleman's rule that wasn't gentle at all: no player could enter the league until his college class graduated. It didn't matter if your mother was picking cotton in Mississippi, as Spencer Haywood's had. It didn't matter if you were the best player in the world at twenty. The NBA told you to wait — unpaid — while everyone else got rich off your name. The colleges loved it. The NBA loved it. The player paid for it.

The ABA looked at that arrangement and did something no established sports league had the nerve to do: it called the rule what it was and broke it. The Denver Rockets signed Spencer Haywood — my high school teammate at Pershing in Detroit, where we won the 1967 Michigan state championship together — under a “hardship” provision. If your family needed the money, the ABA said, you had a right to earn it. Haywood came in and won the ABA's Most Valuable Player award and Rookie of the Year *in the same season*. So much for young players not being ready.

I WALKED THROUGH THAT DOOR

One year later, that same door opened for me. I was averaging twenty-nine points a game as a sophomore at Michigan State, and my family in Detroit knew all about hardship. The Denver Rockets offered me a professional contract, and the ABA's hardship rule made it possible for me to take it. Understand what that meant in 1970: the NBA would not touch me for two more years. The ABA looked at a twenty-year-old and said what nobody in power had ever said to us — *your talent is yours, and your time is now.*

When Haywood later jumped to Seattle and fought the NBA's eligibility rule all the way to the United States Supreme Court — and won, in 1971 — the pathway opened for everyone who followed. Moses Malone going pro out of high school in 1974? ABA. Every “one-and-done” who ever fed his family early, every kid who got to make his own decision about his own career — that lineage runs straight back to the league with the tricolor ball. The NBA fought that freedom in federal court. Remember that the next time someone tells you which league was on the right side of history.

TWO BIDDERS CHANGE EVERYTHING

The hardship rule was one piece of a bigger economic revolution. Before 1967, a basketball player negotiated with exactly one buyer, and one buyer sets the price. The ABA created a market:

- **Salaries exploded.** Average pay across both leagues multiplied several times over in nine years, because a man with two offers is a man with leverage. Veterans who never touched an ABA floor got raises they owed entirely to our existence.

- **Stars gained power.** When Rick Barry jumped leagues, when Julius Erving's contract became the center of the basketball universe, the era of the player as property began to die.
- **The lawsuits landed.** The Haywood decision and the Oscar Robertson suit — settled the same year as the merger — dismantled the machinery that bound a player to one team for life. The ABA's competitive pressure was the crowbar in every one of those doors.

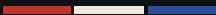
THE POINT MOST HISTORIES MISS

People frame the ABA's aggressive signings as piracy. But every "raid" was simply a man being offered more for his labor. The league that trusted young Black athletes with money, freedom, and creative control in 1970 was not the one in New York with the television deal. If the modern player owns his career — and he does — he inherited that ownership from us.

Freedom brought the talent, and the talent is where this argument gets unfair. Because the greatest basketball player of the 1970s never played a minute in the NBA until he was twenty-six years old — and by then, we'd already seen his best. Let me tell you about the Doctor.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Doctor Operated in the Dark



You saw Julius Erving in the NBA. I'm here to tell you: you saw the encore.

Every argument about the ABA eventually arrives at one man, so let's go straight there. Julius Erving — Dr. J — is the single greatest piece of evidence in this book, because the whole world got to watch the comparison run in both directions. Five years in the ABA. Eleven in the NBA. Hall of Fame in both lives. And everyone who saw both, teammate or opponent, will tell you the same thing I will: **the ABA Doctor was the better Doctor.**

The numbers alone make the case — in the ABA, Julius averaged over 28 points a game across five seasons, won three scoring titles, three MVPs, and two championships with the New York Nets, and took home the MVP of our final All-Star Game. In the NBA he was magnificent for a decade and averaged 22 a night. Magnificent — and diminished. The NBA got a brilliant, polished, twenty-six-year-old professional. We had the twenty-two-year-old force of nature with the huge hands, the bigger afro, and no ceiling on his imagination, playing in a league whose spacing and pace let him be everything he was.

WHAT I SAW FROM THE FLOOR

I guarded that man. I chased him in transition, which is like chasing a rumor. What the surviving film clips can't give you is the *frequency* — the fact that the impossible happened every single night. The rock-the-cradle windmills, the baseline take-offs, the coast-to-coast one-man breaks where he'd rise over two defenders and kiss the ball off the glass like he was placing it on a shelf. In the NBA years they built statues out of two or three Erving plays — the baseline scoop against the Lakers, the free-throw-line dunk. In the ABA, plays like that were *Tuesday*. We didn't even always have cameras there. The greatest show in basketball history ran for five years off-Broadway, and the NBA's historians have treated it like it didn't count.

*The tragedy isn't that the NBA never saw the real Doctor.
The tragedy is that they saw enough to know exactly what
they'd missed — and wrote their history books anyway.*

THE TEST CASE THAT SETTLES THE LEAGUE ARGUMENT

Erving matters to this book for a reason bigger than highlights. He is the controlled experiment:

1. **Same player, both leagues.** His dominance did not shrink because the competition got stiffer; his *game* shrank because the NBA's slower, tighter, three-point-less basketball gave genius less room to operate. The league changed him more than he changed.
2. **First year over, NBA conquered.** The moment he arrived — sold to Philadelphia in the merger's ugliest transaction, which we'll get to in Chapter 12 — he took the 76ers straight to the NBA Finals. No

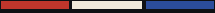
adjustment period. No humbling. The “inferior” league’s best player was immediately the new league’s main attraction.

3. **The brand tells the truth.** The NBA built its entire late-70s and 80s marketing revival around Erving’s flight and flair — an aesthetic manufactured 100 percent in the ABA. They didn’t just buy our teams. They bought our identity and put their logo on it.

And here’s the part that should really keep NBA loyalists up at night: Julius wasn’t alone. He wasn’t even always the best player on the floor those years. The night I want to tell you about next, there were four or five men in one building who belonged on any all-time list — and every one of them was ours.

CHAPTER FIVE

Iceman, Skywalker, and the A-Train: A Talent Audit



Put our best five against their best five, any year from 1972 to 1976. I like our chances. I love our chances.

Talk is cheap, so let's do the audit. Here is a sample of the men who were playing ABA basketball in the league's prime years, with what they proved after the merger — because the "after" is what silences every skeptic.

ABA STAR	IN OUR LEAGUE	THEN, IN THE NBA
Julius Erving	3 MVPs, 3 scoring titles, 2 rings	MVP (1981), 1983 champion, first-ballot Hall of Fame
George Gervin	All-Star wing, unguardable finger roll	4 NBA scoring titles, Hall of Fame
Moses Malone	Pro at 19, straight from high school	3 NBA MVPs, 1983 champion and Finals MVP, Hall of Fame
David Thompson	Rookie of the Year, All-Star MVP (1976)	73-point game, perennial All-Star, Hall of Fame
Artis Gilmore	MVP + Rookie of the Year (1972), 1975 champion	Six-time NBA All-Star, retired among the most efficient scorers ever, Hall of Fame
Dan Issel	Scoring champion, 1975 champion	A decade of 20-point seasons in Denver, Hall of Fame
Rick Barry	NBA scoring champ who jumped to us; ABA scoring champ too	Returned, won 1975 NBA title and Finals MVP, Hall of Fame
Spencer Haywood	MVP + Rookie of the Year, same season (1970)	Four-time NBA All-Star, champion, Hall of Fame
George McGinnis	Co-MVP (1975), 2 rings in Indiana	Immediate NBA All-Star, Hall of Fame

Connie Hawkins	First ABA MVP, 1968 champion	Instant NBA All-Star once the league lifted its ban, Hall of Fame
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Read the right-hand column again. Every one of those men crossed into the “better” league and dominated it — scoring titles, MVPs, championships, Springfield. Not one of them needed a development year. There is no honest way to look at that table and conclude the ABA’s top shelf was second-rate. The evidence says the opposite: our stars were *ahead* of the NBA’s curve, and the NBA spent the late seventies and eighties being renovated by them.

THE ICEMAN

George Gervin came to us as a skinny kid out of Eastern Michigan, and I watched him become the smoothest scorer who ever lived. The finger roll from distance — releasing that ball from eleven, twelve feet with touch like he was dealing cards — was developed on ABA floors against ABA athletes. The NBA didn’t make Ice; the NBA *inherited* Ice, fully formed, and he immediately reeled off four scoring titles in their league. Where’s the adjustment a player supposedly needed coming from the “weak” league? There wasn’t one. There never was, for any of us.

SKYWALKER

David Thompson chose the ABA over the NBA in 1975 when both leagues drafted him first overall — think about what that choice tells you about how players themselves ranked the two leagues. My Denver squad got him, and I got a nightly courtside seat to a 44-inch vertical attached to a scorer’s brain. Michael Jordan grew up on David Thompson and said so; when Jordan went into the Hall of Fame, he asked Thompson to

present him. The aesthetic lineage of the NBA's greatest icon runs directly through an ABA rookie. Case closed on which league was manufacturing the future.

THE A-TRAIN

Artis Gilmore was seven-foot-two of quiet violence — rookie MVP for Kentucky, a champion in 1975, and the anchor of the argument that our big men matched anybody's. They'll tell you the NBA had Kareem, and it did — the greatest of that era, I'll give them one. But behind him? We had Gilmore, Malone, Issel, Haywood, Beaty, Mel Daniels with his two MVPs. Depth for depth at every position, from 1972 on, the ABA's top hundred could stand with theirs — and our top ten flat-out beat theirs anywhere but center. The NBA knew it too. That's why they wanted the merger more than we did by the end.

But stars are only half my case about talent. The other half is sadder, and it's the reason this book exists. Because for every Gervin who made it across the bridge, there was a Roger Brown — a legend you were never allowed to meet.

CHAPTER SIX

The Ones History Left in the Dark



Some of the best basketball players of the twentieth century played their whole primes where the cameras weren't.

Roger Brown may be the finest one-on-one forward you have never seen play. Banned by the NBA in the early sixties over a guilt-by-association scandal he was never convicted of anything in, Brown was driving a forklift in Dayton when the brand-new Indiana Pacers made him their first signing. All he did after that was become the engine of a three-championship dynasty, torch playoff defenses for forty-point games, and earn a reputation — from Julius Erving himself — as a man with moves the Doctor borrowed. The Hall of Fame finally called him in 2013. Roger died in 1997. Sit with that timeline for a moment.

That is the second half of my talent argument: the ABA's greatness wasn't just its exports. It was a whole civilization of players who peaked between 1968 and 1976, out of the national spotlight, and were then quietly erased because their primes didn't happen on NBA film.

SAY THEIR NAMES

- **Mel Daniels.** Two ABA MVP awards, three championships in Indiana, the meanest rebounder in our league. Waited until 2012 for the Hall of Fame — over three decades after he stopped playing.
- **James Silas.** “The Snake.” San Antonio’s closer before the term existed. George Gervin will tell you straight: in the ABA years, it was Silas’s team. A catastrophic knee injury right at the merger stole his NBA proof, and so history pretends he wasn’t elite. I guarded him. He was elite.
- **Louie Dampier.** Nine ABA seasons in Kentucky, the league’s all-time leader in points, assists, and games, and the greatest volume three-point shooter of his generation — a full decade before the NBA legalized the shot he’d already mastered. Hall of Fame: 2015.
- **Freddie Lewis and Mack Calvin.** Champion floor generals, All-Star after All-Star, running offenses at a tempo NBA point guards wouldn’t be asked to play for another twenty years.
- **Warren Jabali.** Maybe the most physically devastating guard of the era — a Finals MVP and an All-Star Game MVP who played with a force that would trend on social media every night if it happened today.
- **Marvin Barnes.** Before the troubles swallowed him, “Bad News” was a twenty-four-and-fifteen force for the Spirits of St. Louis. Ask anyone who saw the 1974–75 season what a healthy, focused Marvin was: a top-five talent in either league.

WHY THE ERASURE HAPPENED

Understand the machinery. When the merger came, the NBA did not welcome ABA history — it quarantined it:

1. **The statistics were segregated.** ABA points didn't count in NBA record books. Louie Dampier's threes, Mel Daniels's boards, my own twenty-seven-a-night season — officially, for decades, none of it happened. (Only in recent years has the NBA begun folding ABA numbers into combined records — a half-century late.)
2. **The film barely exists.** No national TV deal meant no archive. You can watch Wilt and Russell in crisp footage; you have to hunt for grainy minutes of Roger Brown. Memory needs media, and we were denied the media.
3. **The storytellers had a side.** The men who wrote basketball's official history in the eighties worked for, or around, the NBA. Nobody markets the greatness of the rival they bought and buried.

A league's quality isn't proven only by its famous names. It's proven by how good its forgotten names were. Ours were All-Stars. Ours were MVPs. Ours were Hall of Famers who had to wait until their seventies — or their graves — for the letter.

And the men drawing up the plays for all that buried talent? They were the sharpest minds in the sport — and unlike our players, the NBA never even pretended *they* weren't better. It just hired them all.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Chess Masters: Why Our Coaches Were Years Ahead



If ABA basketball was a lesser game, explain why the NBA spent the next thirty years being coached by ABA men.

Larry Brown coached me in Denver, and I'll tell you what practice was like: it was school. Spacing drills before "spacing" was a word broadcasters used. Full-court pressure as a system, not a gimmick. An offense built on movement and trust, where the ball found the open man because the structure guaranteed somebody would *be* open. Larry was in his early thirties, fresh off being one of our smartest point guards, and he was already teaching what he'd later call "playing the right way" — the philosophy that eventually won him an NCAA title at Kansas and an NBA championship in Detroit. He remains the only coach to win both. He learned his trade in *our* league.

THE COACHING TREE TELLS ON THEM

Run down the bench bosses of the ABA and look at what the NBA later paid them to do:

- **Larry Brown** (Carolina, Denver) — NBA champion, Hall of Fame.
- **Hubie Brown** (Kentucky, 1975 ABA champion) — two-time NBA Coach of the Year, the man who basically invented the modern ten-

man rotation and taught two generations of coaches through his clinics and broadcasts. Hall of Fame.

- **Doug Moe** (ABA player and assistant, then Denver's head man) — brought the passing-game offense to the NBA, won Coach of the Year, and made Denver the highest-scoring show in the league for a decade.
- **Kevin Loughery** (New York Nets) — won two of the ABA's last three titles managing the Erving show, then spent twenty years as an NBA head coach, including handing a rookie named Michael Jordan the keys.
- **Slick Leonard** (Indiana) — three championships, the greatest bench general in ABA history, Hall of Fame.
- **Bob Bass, Stan Albeck, Al Bianchi, John MacLeod...** — the NBA's sidelines and front offices of the eighties were staffed floor to ceiling with ABA alumni.

This is the quiet part of the merger nobody says out loud: the NBA didn't just take four franchises and a few dozen players. It took the ABA's *brain*. And unlike the players, the coaches walked into the "superior" league and were instantly treated as innovators — because they were carrying a decade of ideas the NBA had never been forced to develop.

WHY OUR BENCH WAS SMARTER: NECESSITY

ABA coaches worked without a net. Small budgets, small staffs, rosters that could be sold out from under you midseason, and a rules package — the three-point line above all — that demanded genuine strategic thought. When a made basket can be worth 50 percent more from certain spots on the floor, coaching becomes geometry. Where do you station shooters? When do you hunt the deep ball — trailing late, or

all game long? How do you defend a floor that's twenty-five feet wide instead of fifteen? ABA staffs wrestled with those questions for nine years while NBA coaches never had to think past the mid-range. When the NBA finally adopted the arc in 1979, an entire league's coaching establishment had to start learning what Hubie Brown and Doug Moe already knew cold.

Pressure defense was the same story. With rosters thinner than the NBA's, our coaches systematized effort — trapping schemes, ten-man rotations, situational substitution patterns — to steal wins from more talented payrolls. Those are the bones of modern NBA coaching. Ask any coach under sixty where the rotation science and the pace-and-space geometry in today's game came from, and if they're honest, the trail runs to gyms in Louisville, Denver, and Uniondale.

THE STANDARD I HOLD

A league's coaching quality is measured by one thing: does the sport *copy* it afterward? Nobody copied 1974 NBA coaching. Everybody — to this day — copies what our benches were doing. That's the whole verdict, delivered by history itself.

Coaches need tools, though, and the ABA handed its coaches a toolbox the NBA didn't even believe was legal. Let's inventory everything the modern game "invented" — twenty years after we did.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Everything the NBA “Invented” — We Did First



Modern basketball is an ABA tribute act that forgot to credit the band.

Strip today’s NBA down to the things fans actually love about it. The three-point shot that decides every game. The dunk contest and the All-Star weekend spectacle. The teenage phenom drafted on potential. The up-tempo, spaced-floor offense. The player as entertainer, celebrity, and brand. Now check the patent office: every single one of those was an ABA product, road-tested between 1967 and 1976 while the NBA called it all a circus.

THE MASTER LIST

INNOVATION	ABA (1967–76)	NBA ADOPTION
Three-point line	League signature from day one, 1967	1979–80 season — now the axis of the entire sport
Slam dunk contest	All-Star halftime, Denver, 1976	1984 — became All-Star Weekend's crown jewel
All-Star Game as entertainment event	Music, spectacle, showmanship throughout	Rebuilt on our template in the mid-1980s
Underclassmen & prep-to-pro signings	Hardship rule, 1969; Moses Malone from high school, 1974	Forced by the courts, then embraced as the lifeblood of the draft
Pace-and-space offense	Our default style for nine years	Canonized by analytics thirty-five years later
Marketing individual stars	Sold Erving, Gervin, Thompson as attractions	The Bird–Magic–Jordan playbook, and every playbook since
Regional-identity franchises in “small” markets	Indiana, San Antonio, Denver, Kentucky	Three of those four are NBA institutions today

THE THREE-POINTER DESERVES ITS OWN SERMON

The NBA didn't merely decline to adopt the three-point shot for twelve years — its establishment openly ridiculed it as a gimmick for a gimmick league. Meanwhile Louie Dampier was launching them by the hundreds, our coaches were building late-game strategy around the arc, and our fans were learning the particular electricity of a deep ball with the clock dying — a feeling that is now the NBA's single most valuable product. Today a professional game routinely features seventy three-point attempts, and the shot the NBA mocked generates billions of dollars a year for the men who mocked it. If the ABA had negotiated a royalty on the arc instead of a merger, our four teams would own the league.

IT WASN'T LUCK — IT WAS PHILOSOPHY

Seven-for-seven on the biggest innovations in basketball history is not a coincidence. The two leagues ran on different operating systems:

- **The NBA optimized for control** — of players, of style, of the product. Control produces refinement, and refinement produces 1974: technically sound, aesthetically frozen.
- **The ABA optimized for possibility** — what if the shot were worth more? What if the kid is ready at nineteen? What if the game leaned into joy? Possibility produces the future. We *were* the future, nine years early, and it cost us everything except the vindication.

There's one more invention on the ledger, and it's the deepest one — deeper than any rule. The ABA invented the modern basketball *culture*: the sound, the style, the soul. That one they didn't adopt in 1979 or 1984. That one they absorbed so completely they forgot it was ever ours.

CHAPTER NINE

Afros, Soul, and Showtime Before Showtime



The biggest afro in professional sports belonged to Darnell Hillman. The biggest cultural debt in professional sports belongs to the NBA.

Close your eyes and picture the ABA. I'll bet the picture is somebody rising toward a red, white, and blue ball with a glorious halo of hair. Good — that picture is true. Darnell Hillman's afro was the tallest thing in basketball that wasn't Artis Gilmore. Julius wore his crown. Doc, Ice, Skywalker, Bad News — we had nicknames like bluesmen and style like Saturday night. And none of it was costume. It was the truth of who we were, worn in public, at a time when the establishment league preferred its players quiet, trimmed, and interchangeable.

This is the chapter the documentaries have finally started to get right — if you want to see the era testify for itself, put on *Soul Power* on Prime Video and watch the faces of the men telling these stories. What the ABA built between 1967 and 1976 was the first professional basketball culture that let Black excellence be the *whole* aesthetic: the music in the arena, the rhythm of the game, the hair, the handles, the language, the joy. The ABA at its best felt like the playground perfected — and I mean that as the highest compliment in basketball, because the playground is where the game evolves.

STYLE UNDER CONDITIONS OF FREEDOM

Why did the culture bloom in our league and not theirs? Because culture follows freedom, and the freedom differential was enormous:

- **Creative freedom.** An ABA coach saw a behind-the-back pass as a solution; too many NBA coaches in 1972 saw it as a discipline problem. When expression isn't punished, expression compounds — every night, somebody tried something nobody had ever seen.
- **Personal freedom.** The afros, the sideburns, the fashion — the ABA never asked its men to shrink themselves to make anybody comfortable. The league's attitude was simple: be somebody. Fans came to see *people*, not positions.
- **Economic freedom.** Chapter 3's story is a culture story too. Men who are paid what they're worth, and signed at the age they choose, carry themselves differently. Dignity shows up in your game.

THEY ABSORBED IT AND RENAMED IT

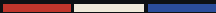
Now run the clock forward. The 1980s "Showtime" Lakers — the fast break as theater. The Jordan era — the player as global icon of flight and style. The dunk contest, the sneaker culture, hip-hop courtside, the NBA selling *cool* to every continent on Earth. Every dollar of that empire is built on the aesthetic foundation our league poured — the fusion of Black culture and basketball that the NBA of the early seventies actively resisted. I don't say that with bitterness; I say it with a witness's precision. The NBA won the business war and then got rich selling the loser's soul. If the truth be told, the most valuable asset transferred in the 1976 merger never appeared on any balance sheet.

The red, white, and blue ball was America's colors. The game we played with it was Black America's genius. The league that mocked both now sells both, worldwide, at a premium.

Culture, coaching, talent, innovation — I've given you the qualitative case. Fair enough, you say, but did the two leagues ever actually *play*? Oh, they played. And the results are the best-kept secret in basketball history.

CHAPTER TEN

Head to Head: The Games They'd Rather You Forget



From 1971 to 1975, ABA and NBA teams met in interleague exhibition games. Final tally: ABA 79 wins, NBA 76. You were never supposed to learn that number.

Every argument about rival leagues eventually hits the same wall: “They never played each other, so we’ll never know.” Except we did play each other. Beginning in the fall of 1971, ABA and NBA clubs met in preseason exhibition games, year after year, more than 150 of them by 1975. The NBA agreed to them assuming its natural superiority would put the upstarts in their place. Instead, over the full run of interleague play, **the ABA won more games than it lost — 79 to 76.**

Let me help you feel the weight of that. The NBA had the older rosters, the referees... actually, no — frequently these games used *NBA-style* conditions, and it didn’t matter. The “minor league,” the “circus,” went out season after season and beat NBA franchises with their full rosters in public, on the record. And as our league matured, the results tilted harder our way — by the final rounds of interleague play in 1975, ABA teams were winning nearly two of every three meetings. The trend line was unmistakable: the gap wasn’t closing, it had *closed*, and it was opening again in the other direction.

“BUT THEY WERE EXHIBITIONS”

Here comes the objection, so let's handle it head-on:

1. **Exhibitions cut both ways.** If preseason results are meaningless, they're meaningless for both sides — yet nobody doubts the NBA would have trumpeted a 79–76 edge from every rooftop in America. The silence around the actual result is itself the tell.
2. **Pride was on the line, and everybody knew it.** I was in those locker rooms. Nobody treated an NBA exhibition like a scrimmage. These were the only nights we could prove it, and NBA teams did not enjoy losing to us in front of their own fans — believe me, they weren't coasting. Some NBA coaches flat-out refused to schedule us again after taking a beating. That is not how anyone treats a meaningless game.
3. **The sample is large.** One upset is noise. A hundred and fifty-five games over five falls, ending in an ABA winning record, is a dataset.

WHAT THOSE NIGHTS WERE LIKE

I'll never forget the feeling of walking into those buildings. The NBA guys would come out loose, half-smirking — and by the second quarter the smirk was gone, because the game was being played at *our* tempo. That was the recurring shock: NBA teams simply weren't conditioned for ABA pace. Their bigs didn't want to run the floor for forty-eight minutes. Their defenses had never accounted for a shooter stationed twenty-five feet out. You could watch, in real time, the future beating the past — four possessions of sprint-and-space and suddenly a proud NBA club was down twelve and calling timeout to talk about it.

THE VERDICT BEFORE THE VERDICT

The 1976 merger is usually framed as the NBA rescuing a drowning league. But the on-court evidence available at the time — five years of interleague results trending our way, and the talent audit from Chapter 5 — supported a very different headline: the NBA moved to buy out a competitor it could no longer reliably beat at basketball. Chapter 13 will show what happened when the buyout put us all in one league. The exhibitions weren't a fluke. They were a preview.

Before the endgame, though, I owe you one night in full. January 27, 1976. My city, Denver. The night our league, financially dying, threw the greatest party in basketball history — and invented the future one more time on the way out the door.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

One Night in Denver: The Dunk Contest Is Born



January 27, 1976. McNichols Arena. The ABA had five months to live, and it spent one of those nights inventing the most famous sideshow in sports.

By January 1976 everybody knew the league was on borrowed time. Franchises had folded midseason; we were down to seven teams. So the ABA did the most ABA thing imaginable: instead of a somber final All-Star Game, it threw a spectacle. The format itself was audacious — the league's first-place team, my Denver Nuggets, against a team of All-Stars from everybody else. Think about the nerve of that: one franchise told to stand in against the best of an entire league. Glen Campbell and Charley Pride performed. The building was packed past capacity with the largest crowd in league history. And Denver — my Denver — beat the All-Stars, 144 to 138.

But the game isn't why the night is immortal. At halftime, some genius in the league office — desperate, inventive, ABA to the bone — staged a competition nobody had ever formalized before: a slam dunk contest. Five men: Artis Gilmore, George Gervin, Larry Kenon, David Thompson, and Julius Erving.

THE DOCTOR TAKES OFF

David Thompson, in his own building, was magnificent — the cradle, the two-handed reverse, bounce passes to himself off the floor. Rocket-launch athleticism, hometown crowd, and for a while it looked like the kid would take it. Then Julius Erving walked to the opposite baseline, turned, and started pacing off steps like a long jumper measuring his runway. The whole arena understood what he was proposing before he did it, and the noise started building while he was still walking. He came down the floor with that afro rolled back like a jet intake, took off from the free-throw line — *the free-throw line* — and threw it down.

You’ve seen the photograph. Everybody’s seen the photograph. When Michael Jordan won the 1988 NBA dunk contest with a free-throw-line dunk, he was quoting Julius, and he said as much. The most replayed image in NBA All-Star history is a cover version of an ABA original, performed at a halftime show the NBA would have told you, that very week, belonged to a doomed carnival league.

READ THE WHOLE NIGHT AS AN ARGUMENT

- **The talent claim, live on stage.** Five contest entrants: four future Hall of Famers. The All-Star rosters that night carried the men who would immediately restock the NBA — Erving, Gervin, Thompson, Gilmore, Issel, and the rest of us.
- **The innovation claim, timestamped.** The dunk contest — today a global television property — has a birth certificate: ABA, Denver, January 27, 1976. Eight years later the NBA adopted it whole, like it adopted everything else.
- **The soul claim, in full color.** Country stars singing, a sold-out house in a “non-basketball” market, the game played above the rim at a

dead sprint, and the greatest showman in the sport's history closing the show. Dying leagues aren't supposed to look like that. Dying leagues don't invent the future at their own funeral.

I played in that building that night, in that uniform, in front of those people. Whatever the ledgers said, nobody standing on that floor believed they were watching an inferior league. We were watching the best basketball on the planet. We just couldn't afford to keep it.

Five months later, the men in suits gathered, and the greatest show in basketball was sold for parts. Let me walk you through the so-called merger — and bring a calculator, because the numbers tell you exactly who was valuable to whom.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The “Merger” That Was Really a Ransom



June 17, 1976. They called it a merger. Read the terms and tell me who was merging with whom.

When two businesses merge, they combine assets and share the future. What happened in June 1976 was something else. Four ABA franchises — the Denver Nuggets, New York Nets, San Antonio Spurs, and Indiana Pacers — were admitted to the NBA on terms that read like a ransom note: each team paid millions of dollars in cash just to walk through the door, received **no share of national television money for years**, and got **no vote** on key league matters during the transition. Our champions weren’t merged. They were fined for existing and then annexed.

THE TERMS, ITEM BY ITEM

- **The entry fee.** Each of the four survivors paid an admission price in the millions — money extracted from franchises the NBA publicly called worthless. You don’t charge millions for worthless.
- **The television blackout.** The four ABA clubs were cut out of national TV revenue while still paying full freight. The NBA kept the money and the narrative.

- **The New York punishment.** The Nets — our reigning champions — owed an additional territorial indemnity to the Knicks for the crime of sharing their market. Squeezed dry, Nets ownership had to sell the contract of Julius Erving to Philadelphia to survive. The NBA's first act upon acquiring basketball's greatest attraction was to financially force his champion team to give him up. The Nets, gutted, collapsed in the standings; the "merger" had taken their franchise player as a processing fee.
- **The abandoned.** The Kentucky Colonels — one of the winningest and best-supported franchises in either league — were bought out and erased. The Spirits of St. Louis were dissolved too, though their owners, the Silna brothers, negotiated a sliver of the four survivors' TV money *in perpetuity* — a clause that eventually paid them hundreds of millions of dollars and stands as the shrewdest deal in sports history. Even in death, ABA people outsmarted the room.
- **The dispersal draft.** The players of the dead franchises were auctioned off. Artis Gilmore went first. A teenager named Moses Malone went in that same dispersal — and NBA front offices, geniuses that they were, let him bounce around before he became a three-time MVP. Our leftovers became their cornerstones.

NOW ASK THE OBVIOUS QUESTION

If the ABA were truly a failed minor league, the NBA had a cheaper option available: wait six months and let it die, then sign the players for nothing. Instead, the NBA moved *before* that could happen. Why? Because a dying ABA was still signing the best college talent in America. Because the Oscar Robertson suit was ending the NBA's reserve-clause plantation economics, and continued war meant continued bidding against us for every star. Because five years of head-to-head results (Chapter 10)

said the product gap ran the wrong way. The NBA didn't absorb the ABA out of charity or conquest. It paid to *stop the fight* — and structured the terms vindictively enough to disguise the payment as a rescue.

THE ONE-SENTENCE TRUTH

The ABA lost the war of balance sheets and television contracts — the only war it was ever losing — and won every other war there was: talent, style, ideas, and, as the next chapter proves beyond argument, the basketball itself.

Because here is the beautiful thing about 1976: the moment the leagues became one, the debate moved out of the barbershop and onto the scoreboard. One league. One schedule. No more "we'll never know." Now we know. Turn the page for the receipts.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Receipts: How ABA Men Took Over the NBA



If the ABA was a minor league, then 1976–77 should have humbled us. Here is what actually happened.

The 1976–77 NBA season was the largest talent experiment in the history of American sports: two allegedly unequal leagues poured onto one schedule overnight. If NBA superiority were real, the ABA arrivals should have thinned out fast — role players, bench guys, a star or two hanging on. Instead, the “minor leaguers” ran the place from opening night.

EXHIBIT A: THE VERY FIRST SEASON

- **The All-Star Game.** In the first post-merger All-Star Game in 1977, **ten of the twenty-four players** were ABA men — from four absorbed teams and a scattering of dispersal picks, against the whole of the established NBA. Julius Erving won the MVP of that game for good measure.
- **The Finals.** The 1977 NBA Finals featured Erving, George McGinnis, and Caldwell Jones carrying Philadelphia against a Portland team whose championship engine included ABA-forged Maurice Lucas — the Finals’ most dominant forward — and ABA

point guard Dave Twardzik. The “absorbed” league’s fingerprints were on both rosters in year one.

- **The scoring columns.** ABA alumni immediately crowded the NBA’s statistical leaderboards — Erving, Thompson, Gervin, McGinnis, Issel, Gilmore — and our franchises won division titles right away, Denver first among them.

EXHIBIT B: THE YEARS THAT FOLLOWED

A fluke season proves nothing, so follow the thread:

- **1978:** The greatest scoring race in NBA history — George Gervin edges David Thompson on the final day, 27.22 to 27.15, Thompson hanging 73 points that afternoon and Gervin answering with 63 that night. Two ABA kids, dueling for the crown of the “superior” league.
- **1979–1983:** Moses Malone — an ABA teenager the dispersal draft treated as an afterthought — wins three NBA MVP awards. Erving wins the 1981 MVP. In 1983 the two of them, together in Philadelphia, produce one of the most dominant championship runs ever recorded. Seven years after the merger, the NBA’s best team was an ABA reunion.
- **The franchises:** The four “charity case” teams became the Spurs’ five-championship dynasty organization, the Pacers’ perennial contender, the Nuggets’ 2023 NBA champions, and the Nets. Half a century of NBA history has been authored by the teams they ransomed in.
- **The sidelines and the record books:** ABA coaches collected NBA Coach of the Year awards and championships (Chapter 7), while ABA-bred players stocked the Hall of Fame class after class, many a generation late (Chapter 6).

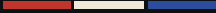
HANDLE THE COUNTERARGUMENT LIKE A PRO

Someone will say: “The ABA’s stars concentrated its talent; its depth was thinner.” Fine — this book’s claim, stated from page one, is about the *top*: the best players, the best coaches, the best ideas. On that claim the post-merger record isn’t evidence; it’s a verdict. The best of the ABA didn’t survive contact with the NBA — it *seized* the NBA: its MVPs, its scoring titles, its Finals, its All-Star Games, its style, and eventually its entire strategic identity. No honest jury reads 1977–1983 any other way.

Those are the receipts, and I’ll match them against anybody’s nostalgia. But I promised you testimony, not just evidence. So let me finally tell you my own story — how a kid from Detroit ended up with the best seat in the house for all of it.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

My Testimony: From Pershing High to the Mile High City



*Every witness has to state his name and how he came to be at the scene.
Here's mine.*

I'm a Detroit kid. I learned my basketball in a city that ran on assembly lines and Motown — where the music taught you rhythm and the factories taught you what work meant, and both of them ended up in my game. At Pershing High School I played alongside Spencer Haywood, and in 1967 we won the Michigan state championship together. Two kids off that one Detroit team would go on to make professional All-Star Games; that's the kind of talent American cities were producing in those years, most of it invisible to the men running the NBA.

I went on to Michigan State, and as a sophomore I averaged twenty-nine points a game. Under the NBA's rules, none of that mattered — I was property-in-waiting, required to stay amateur while my family did without. Then Spencer broke the wall in Denver, and in 1970 the same ABA hardship door opened for me. I signed with the Denver Rockets at twenty years old. I want to be precise about what that felt like, because it's the emotional core of this whole book: the NBA's rules told me to wait my turn. The ABA told me I was a man. You never forget which league said which.

THE DENVER YEARS

Denver became my basketball home, through the Rockets years and the rebirth as the Nuggets. I made five straight ABA All-Star teams, from 1972 through that last, luminous night in 1976. My best season I put up better than twenty-seven points a game, in a backcourt life spent trading rounds with Charlie Scott, Mack Calvin, James Silas, Louie Dampier — and chasing Julius and Ice through open floors. I played for Larry Brown at the height of his young genius, on Denver teams that won at a clip the NBA's best would have envied, in front of crowds that grew from hundreds to a packed McNichols Arena. I lived the whole arc of the league — the empty-gym years, the bidding wars, the artistic peak, the funeral.

And then I crossed over, like the rest of the survivors, into the NBA after the merger — the Detroit chapter, the return to Denver, the wind-down of a career that ended in 1980. I say this with a straight face and a clear memory: the basketball I played and watched in the ABA from 1972 to 1976 was the best basketball I ever saw, in either uniform. The NBA I entered was slower, tighter, more fearful. Talented — deeply talented — but playing yesterday's game while my old league's refugees taught it tomorrow's.

WHAT I CARRIED OUT OF IT

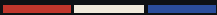
- **Witness standing.** I'm not a historian arguing from box scores. I guarded these men. Every claim in this book about how the ABA *felt* — the pace, the pride of the exhibition nights, the electricity of Denver in January 1976 — is eyewitness testimony.
- **A debt.** The ABA paid me, freed me, and made me. Men like Roger Brown and Mel Daniels never got their flowers in this life. This book is me paying my league back the only way left.

- **A duty to the truth.** Fifty years is long enough to let the winners write the story. If the truth be told, somebody who was there has to tell it. So I am.

One chapter of argument remains: *how* a truth this size got buried — and how you and I dig it out.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Setting the Record Straight



History isn't what happened. History is what got recorded, broadcast, and repeated. Here's how to fix it.

By now you have the full case: the talent (Chapters 4–6), the coaching (7), the innovations (8), the culture (9), the head-to-head record (10), the merger's real terms (12), and the post-merger takeover (13). So finish the argument with me: if all of that is true — and it is documented, checkable, true — why do most fans still “know” the ABA as a failed sideshow?

THE ANATOMY OF AN ERASURE

1. **Television is memory.** The NBA's footage was broadcast, archived, and replayed; ours mostly wasn't. A generation of highlight shows built the myth one clip at a time, simply because clips of us barely existed.
2. **The record books were segregated.** For decades, ABA statistics were treated as unofficial — nine seasons of professional excellence filed under “asterisk.” Only recently has the league begun recognizing combined career numbers, quietly conceding what should never have been contested.

3. **The Hall of Fame slow-walked our men.** Artis Gilmore — Artis Gilmore! — waited until 2011. Mel Daniels, 2012. Roger Brown, 2013, sixteen years after his death. Louie Dampier, 2015. The eventual creation of a special ABA committee to process the backlog was an institutional admission: an entire league's worth of greatness had been left outside the museum.
4. **The framing stuck.** "Merger" instead of buyout. "Absorbed" instead of annexed. "Gimmick" instead of innovation. Language did the burying, and language repeated for fifty years hardens into fact.

THE CORRECTION IS UNDERWAY — JOIN IT

The good news: the truth has been staging a comeback. The documentaries are getting made — watch *Soul Power* on Prime Video and hear the era speak for itself. The remastered ABA footage that survives circulates online and stuns every young fan who stumbles onto it. The NBA now openly celebrates the three-pointer's lineage, retro ABA jerseys outsell half the league's current ones, and combined statistics are finally crediting men who waited a lifetime. Here is how you help finish the job:

- **Tell the story with receipts.** You now hold the interleague record, the merger terms, the 1977 All-Star count, the innovation ledger. Use them — kindly, precisely, relentlessly.
- **Watch and share the testimony.** Every documentary view, every shared clip of Roger Brown or the 1976 dunk contest, is a vote to keep the memory alive while witnesses remain.
- **Honor the names.** When the conversation turns to the greatest ever, say Erving's ABA years out loud. Say Daniels, Brown, Silas,

Dampier, Jabali. Greatness unremembered isn't lesser greatness — it's stolen greatness, and speech is how it gets returned.

They had the cameras. We had the game. Cameras eventually break. The game — the one the whole world plays now — is ours, and it always will be.

CONCLUSION

The Truth Doesn't Need a Television Contract



We began with a story you'd been told: a real league and a sideshow. Now stand where I've stood for fifty years and look at what the evidence actually says.

The best players of the era wore the tricolor ball's colors — and proved it, instantly and overwhelmingly, the moment the leagues became one. The sharpest coaching minds of the next three decades apprenticed on ABA benches. Every pillar of the modern game — the three-pointer, the dunk contest, the teenage phenom, pace-and-space, the player as icon — carries an ABA birthmark. The culture the NBA sells to the planet was forged in our arenas, in our music, under our afros. When the leagues met on the floor, we won more than we lost. And when the war ended, it ended with the NBA *paying* — and then spending half a century being remade in the image of the league it claimed to have rescued.

That is not the biography of an inferior league. That is the biography of a founder written up as a footnote.

WHAT I WANT YOU TO TAKE WITH YOU

- **See the modern game clearly.** Every step-back three, every dunk contest, every nineteen-year-old lottery pick, every up-tempo

masterpiece — that's the ABA, alive and undefeated. Watching today's NBA is watching our vindication in real time.

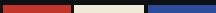
- **Judge institutions by their fruits.** One league protected a broken status quo; the other bet on freedom, youth, and joy — and lost the business while winning the future. Remember which bet aged well. That lesson travels far beyond basketball.
- **Carry the names.** Erving, Gervin, Thompson, Gilmore, Malone, Issel, Haywood, McGinnis, Hawkins, Barry — and Brown, Daniels, Silas, Dampier, Lewis, Calvin, Jabali, Barnes. The first list proves the case. The second list is why the case had to be made.

I was twenty years old when the ABA told me my time was now. I'm an old man telling you the same thing: your time is now. Tell the story. Show the clips. Correct the record, one conversation at a time. The league died in June of 1976. If the truth be told — and now it has been — nothing else about it ever died at all.

— *Ralph Simpson, Denver, 2026*

BONUS SECTION

The Truth-Teller's Kit



Everything you need to win the argument — folded up small enough to carry.

TEN RECEIPTS THAT WIN ANY BARBERSHOP DEBATE

1. Interleague exhibitions, 1971–75: **ABA 79 wins, NBA 76** — with the ABA pulling away in the final years.
2. First post-merger All-Star Game (1977): **10 of 24 players** were ABA men. Erving took the MVP.
3. Julius Erving in the ABA: 3 MVPs, 3 scoring titles, 2 titles, 28-plus a game — then walked into the NBA and reached the Finals in year one.
4. George Gervin crossed over and won **four NBA scoring titles**. No adjustment period.
5. Moses Malone — an ABA teenager — won **three NBA MVPs** and the 1983 title.
6. The three-point line: ABA staple from 1967; NBA adoption 1979; now the axis of the sport.
7. The dunk contest: born at ABA All-Star halftime, Denver, January 27, 1976 — where Dr. J's free-throw-line dunk pre-dated Jordan's by twelve years.

8. The “merger”: four ABA teams paid millions to enter, forfeited years of TV money, and the champion Nets were squeezed into selling Dr. J. Nobody pays ransom for a worthless league.
9. The 1978 scoring race — Gervin 27.22, Thompson 27.15, decided by a 63-point night answering a 73-point afternoon — was an all-ABA duel for the NBA’s crown.
10. Coaching: Larry Brown, Hubie Brown, Doug Moe, Kevin Loughery, Slick Leonard — ABA benches supplied the NBA’s strategic brain for thirty years.

MY ALL-TIME ABA STARTING FIVE (PLUS THE BENCH THAT BEATS ANYBODY)

SLOT	PLAYER	THE CASE
Guard	George Gervin	Smoothest scorer who ever lived; proved it in both leagues
Guard	David Thompson	The prototype for aerial superstardom; Jordan's own idol
Forward	Julius Erving	The greatest ABA player, and the league's living argument
Forward	Roger Brown	The buried legend; the Doctor borrowed from his bag
Center	Artis Gilmore	MVP, champion, and historically efficient in both leagues
Bench	Moses Malone · Dan Issel · Mel Daniels · Spencer Haywood · George McGinnis · James Silas · Louie Dampier · Connie Hawkins · Rick Barry · Warren Jabali	

THE NINE CHAMPIONS — SAY THEM LIKE A PRAYER

- 1968 Pittsburgh Pipers (Connie Hawkins) · 1969 Oakland Oaks (Rick Barry) · 1970 Indiana Pacers
- 1971 Utah Stars · 1972 Indiana Pacers · 1973 Indiana Pacers
- 1974 New York Nets (Dr. J) · 1975 Kentucky Colonels (Gilmore, Issel, Hubie Brown) · 1976 New York Nets (Dr. J)

KEEP DIGGING: A WATCH-AND-READ LIST

- ***Soul Power*** (Prime Video) — the documentary testimony of the era; start here and watch the witnesses tell it.
- **The 1976 ABA All-Star Game and dunk contest footage**— widely circulated online; the single best surviving showcase of what we were.
- **The 1976 ABA Finals (Nets vs. Nuggets)** — often called one of the finest playoff series ever played, in any league.
- ***Loose Balls* by Terry Pluto** — the classic oral history; hundreds of ABA voices, one unforgettable book.
- **Remember the ABA (online archives)** — the fan-kept flame: rosters, statistics, and histories for every team the record books tried to forget.

THE ONE-MINUTE VERSION, FOR WHEN TIME IS SHORT

MEMORIZE THIS PARAGRAPH

“The ABA gave basketball the three-pointer, the dunk contest, the teenage star, pace-and-space, and the player as icon. Its best men — Erving, Gervin, Malone, Thompson, Gilmore — crossed into the NBA and immediately won its MVPs, scoring titles, and championships. Its coaches ran NBA sidelines for thirty years. When the leagues actually played, the ABA won the series. And the NBA paid millions to end the war, then adopted every idea it had mocked. That’s not a failed league. That’s the founder of the modern game — if the truth be told.”